Except just once. This sole exception relates to the settlement of Sringaverapura near the banks of the Ganga, where wood charcoal of bhurjapatra was recovered in an archaeological context of the early first millennium BCE. This suggests a long familiarity with the tree whose bark, in the form of thin papery layers which were peeled off in broad horizontal rolls, was used for writing.[6] Remnants of bhurjapatra have only survived at this one site, and this paradoxically only because the wood got burnt.

As with generations of rulers before him, it is likely that some of Ashoka's official communications would have been recorded on the product of such bark and leaf. The major post-Kalinga revolution in communication was that the emperor ordered several of his promulgations to be inscribed on stone and in public places. These stone edicts have survived remarkably well: found some 2200 years after they were carved, several appear in much the state they were when created. The survival of an ancient document in the shape and place where it was originally inscribed is in itself unusual. What makes it even more so is that, in Ashoka's time, it was relatively rare. Alexander of Macedon, as we saw, went to great lengths to ensure he was remembered, even appointing an official historian for the purpose. This notwithstanding, the available narrative accounts about Alexander date to more than 300 years after him.[7]

Glimpses of rescripts that Ashoka first sent out to his provinces and which were inscribed on his instructions can still be seen at a large number of their original locations because the messages were engraved on immovable rocks and boulders. There is much variety in the kinds of surface upon which they were inscribed. Some are on flattish horizontal rock faces, as at Rajula Mandagiri in the Kurnool district in Andhra, and near Srinivaspuri in New Delhi.[8] Others, such as those at Maski and Nittur in Karnataka, are engraved on vertical surfaces. The rocks are sometimes easily accessible, as at Bairat in the Jaipur district of Rajasthan, where the boulder is at the foot of a hillside; and in the case of the rock face on which